What Would Bring the Family Back to the Plan?

Twelve everyday changes to notice and write down, with no diagnosing.

A plan the family means to come back to needs a reason to come back. Most of those reasons are ordinary things you'd notice anyway: something Mom says, a change in who helps her, a change at home.

This guide names twelve of them and, for each, what to write down. None of them is expected. Mom is well, and this is a page to keep with the plan, not a watch to keep over her.

Your part is to notice and make a note. What a change means, and whether it should move anything in the plan, is for Mom, her doctor and the professionals who assess her. The areas follow the CDC's advice on when to update a care plan and the Family Caregiver Alliance's on when a family should meet again. Three of them, a fall, what Mom says about company and who lives in the house, are the Family Care Roadmap's own examples. The wording about what to write down is ours.

Around Mom

1 **News about her health** [1]

NOTICE Something she's told at an appointment, or Mom mentioning that something feels different.

WRITE DOWN What she said or what she was told, in the words used, with the date.

2 **A change in her medicines** [1]

NOTICE A new prescription, one that has stopped, or a change in when or how she takes something.

WRITE DOWN What changed and when, as she or the pharmacist described it. Don't adjust anything yourself.

3 **A fall**

NOTICE A fall, whether she tells you about it herself or you hear of it later.

WRITE DOWN When and where it happened, and what she says about it. Leave the reason to her doctor.

4 **What she says about company**

NOTICE Mom saying she's lonely, or mentioning that she sees people less than she used to.

WRITE DOWN Her words, and the date.

5 **Help she starts asking for** [2]

NOTICE Something Mom has always done herself that she now asks someone to do, or to help with.

WRITE DOWN What the task is, who she asked, and since when.

6 **What she says she wants** [3]

NOTICE Mom raising the subject herself, or changing her mind about something she'd told you.

WRITE DOWN What she said, in her words, kept apart from what the family hopes for.

Around the people who help her

7 A change in a helper's own life [4]

NOTICE Someone Mom relies on moving away, changing jobs or taking on something new at home.

WRITE DOWN Who it is, what changed, and which of the things they do for Mom it touches.

8 Help that starts or stops [3]

NOTICE A neighbor who no longer drops by, a relative who has begun doing more, a regular visit that has lapsed.

WRITE DOWN What used to happen, what happens now, and since when.

9 Small things adding up for one person [5]

NOTICE The errands, calls and rides one person does for Mom, and whether the list is getting longer.

WRITE DOWN A week's list of who did what. It's a list, not a complaint.

10 How you're doing yourself [6]

NOTICE Feeling overwhelmed, feeling alone in it, sleeping too much or too little, or feeling tired most of the time.

WRITE DOWN What you've noticed and since when. Mention it to your own doctor.

Around the household

11 Who lives in the house

NOTICE Someone moving in or out, or a change in who is at home during the day.

WRITE DOWN Who, when, and what they used to do around the house.

12 Her doctors and the people to call [1]

NOTICE A new doctor, one who has retired, an emergency contact whose number has changed.

WRITE DOWN The new name and number, and the date you updated the list.

When it's more than a note

If something about Mom's health concerns you, tell her doctor. It doesn't need to wait for the family's next conversation or the date on the plan. For an emergency, call emergency services.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't say what any of these changes means, how much it matters or what should happen next, and it doesn't choose the changes that should reopen your family's plan. Those belong to Mom, her doctor and the people who assess her. Your dated notes give them something to work from.

Ready for the next step?

You know what to notice and where to write it. A change is easier to see against a record of how things are today, and the care interview makes that record: it walks you through Mom's situation area by area and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, Steps for Creating and Maintaining a Care Plan
2. Family Caregiver Alliance, Caregiving at Home: A Guide to Community Resources
3. AARP, Prepare to Care: A Planning Guide for Families
4. Family Caregiver Alliance, Holding a Family Meeting
5. Family Caregiver Alliance, Caregiving with Your Siblings
6. MedlinePlus (National Library of Medicine, NIH), Caregiver Health